

CONDUCTING A MEETING

Introduction

- ✓ What is a meeting?
 - Is an assembly of people for a particular purpose, especially for formal discussion
 - A meeting is any gathering of two or more persons aiming at collectively accomplishing what one person cannot.
 - However, not all meetings we see/attend are really necessary



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- Many meetings don't need to be held, and often those that are held are attended by more people than necessary
- Often times there are more efficient ways to "meet" your objectives without holding a meeting
- Some of these alternatives include: phone calls, internal memos, letters, circular resolution, e-mails etc.



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- Thus before calling a meeting, one needs to decide if a meeting is necessary.
- When scheduling or attending your next meeting, clearly define the objectives for yourself or the group if you are the person responsible for the meeting.
- To help you think through the objectives, ask yourself the following four questions:



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- i. Why am I scheduling or attending this meeting?
- ii. What do I want to accomplish or gain?
- iii. What information will be exchanged or decisions made?
- iv. Who will be attending that I need to meet or gain their support?



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- ❑ Once you have clarified your objectives, you still need to determine if a meeting is the best way to achieve them.
- ❑ To make sure a meeting will be the best use of resources (time, money and energy) for all concerned, determine if it will be used for at least one of the following:

❖ Common Functions of a Meeting

- ✓ To convey new information to a group
- ✓ To answer important questions
- ✓ To participate in group decision making



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- To brainstorm on important ideas
 - To solve existing problems etc.
- ☐ If you have determined a meeting is the best avenue to carry out objectives, then you should begin to organise for an effective meeting.



Types of Meetings

- ❑ Meetings can be of various types based on formality, timing, purpose, use, legality, participation etc.
- ❑ Some examples are;
 - i. Formal meetings
 - ii. Informal meetings
 - iii. Annual General Meetings (AGM)
 - iv. Statutory meetings
 - v. Board meetings
 - vi. Ad hoc/extra-ordinary meetings



How to Organise for a Meeting

- Good meetings are not accidents - they are the result of good planning
- The time you spend in planning, will result in major benefits later by efficiently using the meeting time, accomplishing objectives, and avoiding the need for follow-up meetings.
- When deciding to hold a meeting, you should also decide who should attend and what the purpose of the meeting is.
- To help in planning meetings; *Below is a checklist of major elements essential for meeting success*



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(a) Purpose

- Plan meetings with purpose
- Define the purpose or objective of the meeting

(b) Participants

- Who need to attend this meeting to accomplish the purpose?

(c) Structure

- How should the meeting be organised to best accomplish the purpose?



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Some techniques may include:

- Guest speakers,
 - Videos,
 - Brainstorming sessions,
 - Panel sessions, discussion groups, demonstrations, etc.
- ❖ Whatever technique is selected, it should have the greatest impact on the participants to attain the meeting objectives.



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(d) Location

- Select a meeting place that best matches the participant's needs, the objectives, and the meeting structure.
- When planning where to meet give consideration to:
 - ✓ The number of participants,
 - ✓ Comfortability of the venue: ventilation, chairs quality etc.



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- ✓ Accessibility,
- ✓ Adequate parking,
- ✓ Room acoustics: microphones, free from echo sound
- ✓ Equipment needs: sockets, projectors, computers, cables.



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(e) Time

- Choosing a meeting time depends on the availability of participants and meeting facilities.
- The anticipated length of the meeting should also be a factor in deciding when to schedule the meeting.



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(f) Distribution of Responsibilities

- There should be a mutual understanding of not only the meeting purpose, but also individual assignments and how they fit into the total programme.
- Those meetings that are more focused on brainstorming or creativity may require little or no individual assignments.
- In task-oriented or policy deciding meetings, it is best to prepare a written summary of assigned duties so individuals know what their responsibility is for the meeting.



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(g) Confirmation

- Contact all participants a week to three days before the meeting day.
- Contact can be as simple as sending everyone a friendly reminder through office e-mail, phone calls etc.
- For regularly scheduled meetings, choose a location and meeting time and try not to change it.
- Participants are required to confirm their attendance before the meeting day.



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(h) Agenda

- Agenda is a list of items/issues to be discussed at a meeting
- Meeting agenda is crucial to meeting success in three ways:
 - i. It clarifies the objectives so people understand the meeting purpose and tasks.
 - ii. Distributing the agenda prior to the meeting helps participants plan and prepare to make an effective contribution.
 - iii. During the meeting, the agenda provides direction and focus for the discussion.



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- ❖ There are a variety of agenda presentation styles, but, essentially agenda paper should contain at least the following elements:
 - Title of the meeting (e.g., MUST Convocation Annual General Meeting),
 - Time of commencement (e.g. 09:00 a.m.)
 - Date of the meeting (e.g. Thursday, 15/12/2022),
 - Venue/location (e.g. Nyerere Hall),
 - List of discussion items (agenda).
- ❖ Some people prefer to include time allocated for each agenda item to improve meeting effectiveness (e.g. review minutes of previous meeting 09:00-09:10 a.m.).



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- ❖ Some of common/standard agenda items are as follows:
 - i. Opening of the meeting
 - ii. Adoption of the agenda
 - iii. Communication from the Chairperson
 - iv. Confirmation of the minutes of the previous meeting (If it is not the first meeting)
 - v. Matters arising from the previous meeting (if it is not the first meeting)
 - vi.
 - vii.
 - viii. A.O.B
 - ix. Adjourning the meeting



How to Run the Meeting Effectively

❑ Begin on time and end on time

- Starting a meeting late sends the message that it's okay to be late and it shows a lack of respect and appreciation for those who make the effort to arrive on time.
- Some people may have back-to-back meetings to attend
- Ending on time shows respect for participant's valuable time, however no one ever complains if you are fortunate enough to end earlier.



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☐ Follow the Agenda

- Review the agenda with participants at the beginning of the meeting (adoption)
- Ask them if any changes need to be made.
- Continually refer back to the agenda throughout the meeting to keep discussion centered on the stated purpose and specified agenda items
- Display or distribute the agenda to members so that everyone refers to the agenda when discussion seems to be getting off track.



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❑ Establish and Use Ground Rules

- Ground rules are clear regulations that the group agrees to follow to help them facilitate productive discussions.
- Ground rules lay out the expectations of "the way things should be done at meeting"
- All group members should reach consensus on following the ground rules.
- Examples of some typically used ground rules include: arrive and start on time; stick to the agenda, everyone participates, only one member to speak at time, respect different viewpoints; show responsibility for following the ground rules etc.



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❑ Control dominating individuals

- Make sure each individual has a fair chance of expressing ideas and opinions.
- Do not let one person dominate the discussion.
- Of equal importance is to ensure that quiet participants are expressing their ideas and opinions.
- This may require the leader or facilitator to directly call on the quiet member and ask them for their opinion or for any ideas they would like to share.



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☐ Motivate members

- Prepare allowances to members as per regulation.
- Prepare meals to energise and motivate participants.
- Soft drinks like water, coffee, juice, soda and bites can be provided as well.
- Preferably, food should be provided at the end of the meeting.



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❑ Summarise

- The Chairperson must summarise the meeting by highlighting some important decisions made, tasks delegated, deadlines, and any action required by participants.
- Include in the summary any review plans for follow-up or the need to schedule any succeeding meetings.
- It is far easier to schedule the next meeting while everyone is at the table than it is to wait and contact each participant individually.

